

STAGE TEN • RELATIONSHIPS & CONNECTIONS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Ten • Relationships & Connections

PURPOSE

Stage Ten is fundamentally about relationships, which makes it, alongside Stage Two, one of the stages where group adaptation matters most. Many of its individual worksheets ask participants to reflect on real relationships they already have; the group versions here let participants practice real relational skills, listening, conflict rehearsal, giving specific recognition, live with each other, not just plan to use them later.

This document adapts eight FIRSTS across all three sections of Stage Ten. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete their own individual reflection first, and the group version tests or deepens it.

A genuine caution specific to this stage: several of these FIRSTS touch real vulnerability (conflict, trust, mentorship uncertainty). Every group adaptation below is designed to stay at an appropriate stakes level for a workshop setting — never push a participant toward disclosure beyond what they've explicitly opted into.

The Eight Adapted Exercises

FIRST N4

Conflict Resolution with a Friend — Role-Reversal Rehearsal

TIME: +15 min beyond solo planning

1. After individually identifying a real, unaddressed tension, pair participants up (not with the actual friend involved — a stand-in).
2. Partner A plays themselves and rehearses opening the real conversation; Partner B plays the friend, responding genuinely based on what they'd expect.
3. Partner B then steps out of role and gives one honest reaction: did that opening feel likely to land well or escalate things?
4. Swap roles using Partner B's real situation.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Rehearsing a difficult opening out loud, even with a stand-in, reduces the activation energy needed to actually have the real conversation afterward. Keep this explicitly hypothetical — no one should reveal private details about the actual friend involved.

FIRST N6

Reflection on Friendship Qualities — Quality Sort

TIME: +10 min beyond solo reflection

1. Give small groups a set of quality cards (trust, humor, honesty, shared interests, reliability, challenge, ease) — physical cards or a shared list.
2. Each person ranks their top 3 privately, then the group compares rankings.
3. Discuss: where did the group agree, and where did genuine differences in what people value in friendship show up?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Seeing genuine variation in what different people value in friendship normalizes that there's no single "correct" formula — useful context before participants finalize their own individual reflection.

FIRST N9

Trust-Building Exercise — Graduated Disclosure Circle

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. In groups of 3–4 (people who already know each other reasonably well), go around with an explicitly low-stakes prompt first: "share one thing most people don't know about you."
2. Second round, slightly deeper: "share a moment you were genuinely proud of but rarely mention."
3. Debrief as a full group: did the second round feel different from the first? What made it possible?

FACILITATOR NOTE

This deliberately uses graduated, low-to-moderate stakes prompts rather than asking for genuine vulnerability cold — appropriate for a workshop setting where trust between participants may still be developing. Never push toward genuinely high-stakes disclosure in a group activity.

FIRST N13

Team Goal Alignment — Silent Alignment Check

TIME: +10 min beyond framing

1. If real project teams are present, each team member privately writes their own one-sentence understanding of the team's actual goal, without discussion.
2. All sentences are revealed simultaneously (written on cards, or shared on screen at once).
3. Team discusses any genuine differences found, and drafts one agreed sentence together.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Simultaneous reveal, not sequential sharing, is what makes this work — sequential sharing lets later speakers anchor to the first answer rather than giving their own genuine, independent read.

FIRST N14

Collaborative Problem-Solving Session — Structured Pair Problem-Solve

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Pairs work on a real, current shared problem (from an actual class project, work task, or the facilitator's prepared prompt if no real one is available).
2. Partner A explains their view of the problem and a possible solution for 2 minutes, uninterrupted. Partner B may only ask clarifying questions.
3. Roles reverse. Only after both have been heard do the pair jointly discuss and converge on an approach.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The uninterrupted-explanation structure directly prevents the most common failure mode named in this FIRST's Common Pitfalls: one partner's solution dominating before the other's reasoning is genuinely heard.

FIRST N17

Group Reflection & Debrief — Round-Robin Pattern Spotting

TIME: +15 min beyond individual reflection

1. After individual reflection on a real shared project, small groups go around naming one specific thing that worked and one that didn't — no discussion yet, just collection.
2. Once everyone has shared, the group looks at the collected list together and identifies any pattern that came up more than once.
3. Groups report their single most surprising shared pattern back to the full room.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Patterns that show up across multiple individual reflections are usually the most genuinely useful insights — this structure surfaces them systematically rather than relying on one person to notice them.

FIRST N19

Recognition of Team Contributions — Specific Shoutout Round

TIME: +10 min beyond framing

1. If real teams are present, each team member names one specific, genuine contribution a teammate made — not a general compliment, an actual concrete thing they did.
2. Go around until everyone has both given and received one specific recognition.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Insisting on specificity (“you caught the error in our data before we submitted it” rather than “you did great”) is what makes this land as genuine recognition rather than empty ritual.

FIRST N23

Thoughtful Question to a Mentor — Question Workshop

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. Each participant drafts 2–3 questions individually first.
2. In pairs, read your questions aloud to a partner, who rates each one: would this question work for literally any mentor, or does it feel genuinely tailored to your specific situation?
3. Revise the weakest question based on that feedback.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A partner is often better positioned than the question's author to spot when a question is actually generic despite feeling specific to the person who wrote it.